A LONGFORM PROFILE · ONE OF 1,000 SYNTHETIC RESIDENTS

The second she looked up, a laptop in the rain became her customer for four years.

Drawn from a 14-day algorithmic wind tunnel running 1,000 simulated residents: a 36-year-old café owner on Lane Cove Plaza lives through the same fortnight in four parallel Lane Coves — the same espresso machine, the same six-a.m. switch, but because of what happens to be in the pockets of the people walking past, four wildly different densities of human weather settle in front of her counter.

> *She has run a shop on this corner for ten years. She knows the names of half the street. The algorithm did not send her anywhere. It merely, quietly, locked the muscles in her neck, and let her go blind on her own corner for an entire decade.*

About this piece

Every sentence in this profile is reconstructed from data produced by the Synthetic Socio Wind Tunnel project — four independent simulations (each running 1,000 agents over 14 days under a different mobile-push policy) of one agent, codename `a_44_0059` : her complete *life_history*, her push deliveries, her dialogue summaries, her reflection logs, and her encounter traces. In the paper she is a row in a table; on the dashboard she is an orange dot with `PF drama = 12.2×` . Here she is a woman who unlocks the shop at six, who knows the names of half the street, and who has written the Wi-Fi password in marker on the front of her counter.

The pronoun *she* does double duty: inside the simulation it is the fixed attribute of a 36-year-old agent; outside the simulation, it points to a person I have assembled — plausibly, but not really — from twenty life-events, four logged conversations, and seventy-three encounters in which someone she did not greet was noticed at the corner of her eye. The street names — Lane Cove Plaza, Longueville Road, Stringybark Creek, Mowbray Road, the AirTrunk data-centre proposal, the Galuwa Wellbeing Centre — are real places and real recent debates in Lane Cove, Sydney. She, however, did not sign that loan; she did not, in any literal sense, meet the programmer soaked through on the Pacific Highway bus stop.

She is one of a thousand synthetic residents. She lives the same 14 days in four universes simultaneously: a *baseline* universe with no push at all; a *hyperlocal_push* universe in which her phone keeps flagging weekend events at the local PLC kindergarten; a *global_distraction* universe whose feed is full of Sydney CBD headlines; and a *phone_friction* universe engineered to make the phone slightly harder to swipe. This piece stacks the four versions over each other and watches the four different streams of foot traffic that crystallise in front of her counter.

1 ◍ Six a.m. She flips the first switch on the machine.

May 18, 2026. Lane Cove Plaza. Fourteen degrees, light southerly. The sky has not yet broken. The streetlamps along Longueville Road are still on, and the bakery next door, as always, has lit its windows before she has lit hers. She arrives from the Burns Bay Road side, walks under the arched entrance of the Plaza with her keys silent in her palm — ten years in, she could walk the last ten steps with her eyes closed.

The door slides open. She flips the first switch on the machine. Counting back from this morning, this is roughly the three thousand seven hundredth time. She is thirty-six. She was twenty-eight when she signed the lease on the small shopfront next to Gallery Lane Cove, and her hand was shaking.[life #1] She walked the length of Longueville Road three times before going back to the agent's office to put her name to the paper.

She is not what you would call *successful* in any photogenic sense. Her shop will only just be ten years old next year. The loan officer at the bank said something at the signing that she has never forgotten:

> *"I've approved a lot of cafés. Fewer than half of them last five years."*
>
> *— The loan manager from the Burns Bay Road branch, who still comes by every Friday for a batch brew. He is still her regular.*[life #16]

She lasted. In those ten years the three-hundred-metre strip of Lane Cove around her has also rearranged itself. The month the Lane Cove Tunnel opened, the flow on Epping Road dropped by a third overnight; the drive-by traffic that used to stop for a coffee simply stopped existing. To survive, she invented a subscription-delivery side of the business; that quarter of her monthly revenue is still there today.[life #15] When the Crows Nest Metro broke ground in the summer of 2023, the vibration travelled along this street, and her regulars who lived off Pacific Highway came in saying "the cups in our cupboards are rattling." For a few months she had an unexpected new shift — refugees from the noise, working from the corner table — and she wrote the Wi-Fi password in black marker across the front of the counter.[life #7]

Her life has no theatrical hook — she is not a divorced mother, not a retired artist, not a worker conscripted into anyone's political essay. She is, simply, the woman who owns a small café on the Plaza. But she is a **node**. On this three-hundred-metre stretch of Lane Cove she knows, roughly, who lives where, who does what, who is worrying about what this week. Her shop is the most stable observation post in the area. She can feel, approximately, how many faces have drifted past the counter each day.

Three fixed facts about her

- **Tuesday afternoons**, she cycles a week's supply of beans over to Marco, the concierge at the St Leonards apartment block. Marco always leaves an espresso for her on the staff kitchen counter so she can "criticise it." That arrangement has been steady for four years.[life #9]
- **Tony**, who runs Berry Café three hundred metres down, has been her "intelligence ally" for two decades. Whenever there is sewerage work or a road closure on Longueville Road, Tony texts her. Last summer they jointly blocked a hike in the outdoor-seating fee together.[life #6]
- The "local artists' wall" inside the shop currently holds **seven paintings**. The first came, three years ago, from a woman who used to sit in the corner with a sketchbook and who later became the Gallery Lane Cove resident artist.[life #8]

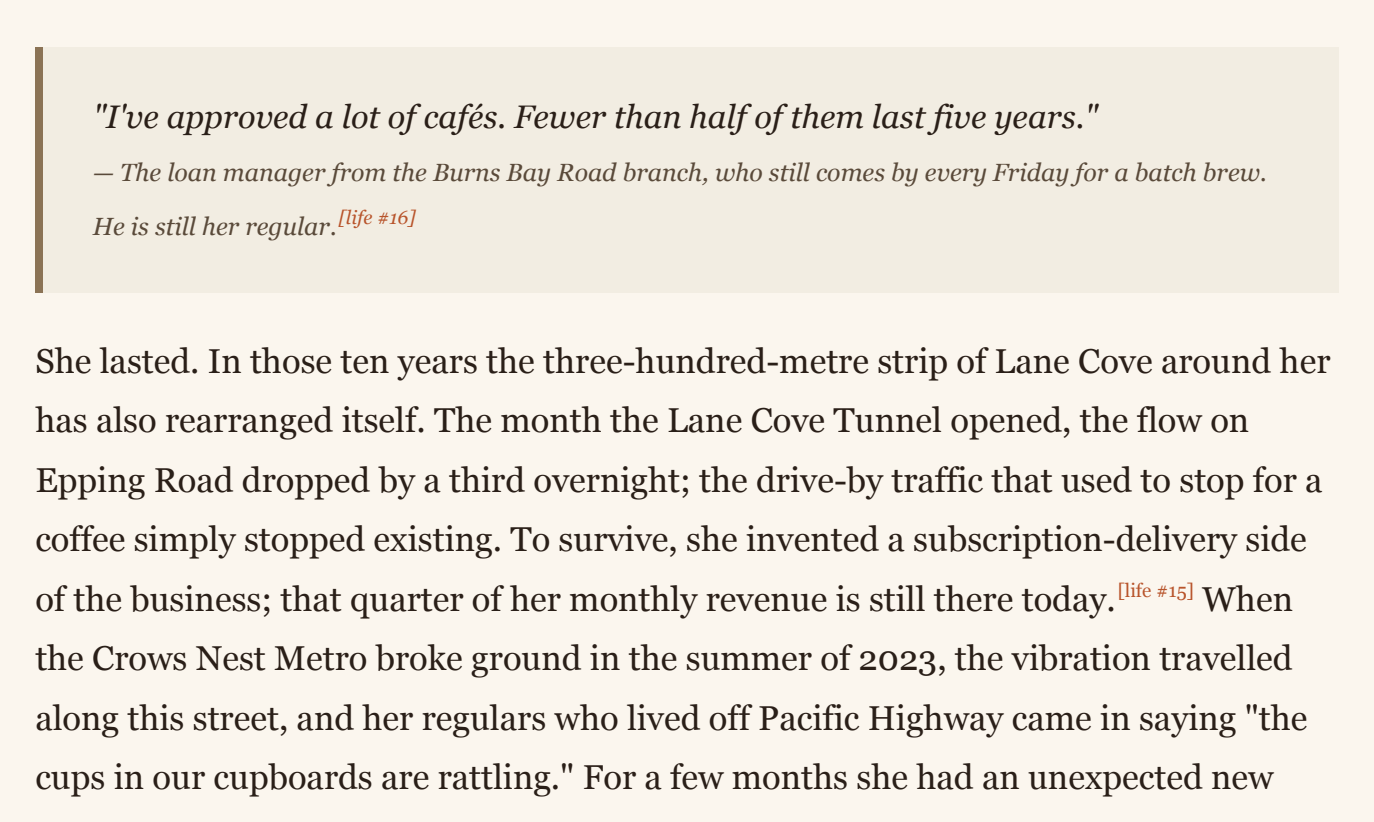
Where her family touches the street

Her child goes to Lane Cove West Public School. Five years ago, on *registration day*, she queued at the school gate at five in the morning to hand in the forms; a dozen parents were already ahead of her. The Indian mother who lined up behind her that morning is now part of her fixed early shift — five years of mornings shared, five years of school drop-offs, two children who grew up in the same class — and the only name they have ever known each other by is still **"no sugar."** Chinese names, English names, neither has ever been exchanged.[life #11] This is the Lane Cove school-zone economy: a single registration morning can supply a café with five years of early-morning trade.

Her relationship to the city: a string of forced reinventions

This passage is not romantic. In ten years of running the shop she has been forced to retool by something external nearly every year. Lane Cove Tunnel opens → she invents the subscription route. Crows Nest Metro breaks ground → she takes in the noise refugees. Chatswood adds three new speciality micro-roasters → she strikes an unofficial deal with a retired engineer who roasts beans in his own garage up in Lane Cove North, and starts selling a label called **"North Garage Roast."**[life #16][#17] What is rarest in a small-business owner is not *vision*; it is the ability to still be open after every shift in the weather outside.

That is her. The kind of person who lets the storm-damaged signboard stay crooked and calls the crack a souvenir. The crack is still there today.[life #12]



Her three-hundred-metre radius of Lane Cove — the Plaza is the observation post, Longueville Road the artery, Gallery Lane Cove the supplier of artists, Stringybark Creek the back lane she takes when Mowbray Road is jammed.[atlas + life 1/2/4/8]

2 ◍ The people on the other side of the counter

This chapter is not a lyric. It is a list. The people she remembers, in rough order of frequency, each pinned to one specific story in her memory. Because to the woman who owns the café, people are not abstract *customers*; they are faces that walked through the door on some particular morning in some particular rainstorm in some particular year.

These seven are the stable structure of the line on the other side of her counter. She remembers, of course, more than seven — ten years on this block, she has met half the street — but these are the seven who keep surfacing in her first-person memory.

Alan, the retired lawyer

`Every morning at 7:00 · flat white · double espresso`

Met: the spring of her second year in business

The spring of her second year, she set up a temporary stand at the Canopy Park community market selling single-origin pour-over beans. That day she picked up a dozen of the customers who would prove the most loyal for the next decade — including a retired lawyer named Alan who showed up at seven every morning for a flat white. Alan is still the first one in the door.

`Source: her life-history event #3`

Mrs. Chen

`Occasionally · long black, decaf · with a white West Highland terrier on a lead`

Met: her third month in Lane Cove

A Chinese-Australian woman who walks past the Plaza in the mornings. From the first cycle of chemotherapy through to remission — she watched, over those years, Mrs. Chen's dog Mochi age from middle years into stiffness. Mrs. Chen has never once ordered an espresso. Only ever a long black, decaf. She has never asked why.

`Source: her life-history event #4`

Tony, who owns Berry Café

`Intelligence exchange · never her coffee (he runs his own shop)`

Met: a twenty-plus-year alliance of local intelligence

The two shops are three hundred metres apart. Whenever there's drainage work or a road closure on Longueville Road, Tony texts. Last summer the two of them jointly blocked a hike in outdoor-seating fees. They are supposed to be competitors. In practice they are the two most reliable small businesses on the Plaza.

`Source: her life-history event #6`

The Indian mother · 8:30 a.m. shift

`Every morning at 8:30 · latte · no sugar`

Met: at the school registration day, 5 a.m., the woman directly behind her in line

Five years ago at Lane Cove West Public School registration: 5 a.m., she was ahead in the line, the other woman was behind. Their two children went on to share the same classroom for five years. Five years of mornings, five years of school gates, two children who grew up together — and the name they call each other by is still only **'no sugar.'** Neither has ever exchanged a Chinese name or an English one.

`Source: her life-history event #11`

The retired engineer · North Garage Roaster

`Bean supplier · weekly delivery, stays for a drip`

Met: six years ago, in his own garage up in Lane Cove North

A retired engineer in Lane Cove North who roasts beans in his garage. His Ethiopian naturals are better than anything she has ever sourced from a major label. They struck an unwritten deal: he roasts, she sells, the label reads 'North Garage Roast.' Last year, when Chatswood added three speciality cafés, this is the differentiation that kept her shop open.

`Source: her life-history event #17`

Marco · St Leonards concierge

`Every Tuesday afternoon · she cycles a week of beans over`

Met: four years ago, when the small side-business began

The concierge at the St Leonards apartment block. Every Tuesday afternoon she cycles over a week's beans. Marco always leaves a single espresso on the staff-kitchen counter for her to 'criticise.' Over four years, that espresso has become her most stable peer review.

`Source: her life-history event #9`

The loan manager

`Every Friday · batch brew · no sugar, no milk`

Met: at the Burns Bay Road bank branch, the day she signed the small-business loan

The loan officer who approved her small-business loan years ago. He has come in every Friday since. The line of his she remembers most clearly: 'I've approved a lot of cafés. Fewer than half of them last five years.' Next year her shop turns ten.

`Source: her life-history event #16`

A small thing worth pausing on: not one of these seven was introduced to her by a municipal app, by a push notification, or by an algorithmic neighbour-recommendation. Every single one of them surfaced in a specific, physical, accidental moment — a stall at a community market, a queue at a school registration, somebody else opening a business next door, the unexpected goodness of a batch of garage-roasted beans, an espresso left out on a staff-kitchen counter by a concierge at St Leonards.

This chapter is the premise of everything that follows. When we get to the chapter where hyperlocal_push fires thirty extra "family weekend market" notifications, where phone_friction lets her look up at twelve times as many faces — the real question is: **can any of these algorithmic interventions actually produce an eighth, or a ninth, stable acquaintance?**

3 ◍ The afternoon she picked up a laptop at the Pacific Highway bus stop

A Wednesday four years ago. Raining. Around 4:50 p.m.

> *Beyond the seven fixed faces of the previous chapter, there are a great many other people on the other side of her counter — most of them drift through and leave no trace. But occasionally someone who was never going to stop ends up inside the one-second window of her looking up, and turns into the eighth, or the ninth, stable acquaintance. The grace, however, has a quiet precondition: she did not, in that one second, lower her head to a phone. What follows is one such accident — and, of everything outside her seven regulars, the single relationship that most resembles the kind of chance encounter this simulation is built to test.*

She was, originally, just waiting for the 144. The afternoon rush was over and she wanted to be early at the school gate. She was not on her phone that day — possibly because the battery was nearly out, possibly because nothing seemed worth scrolling. She raised her head, and looked over at the bench by the shelter.

On it was a soaked-through backpack. No one near it. She waited something like a minute. No one came back.

She could have left it. A few hundred people pass through that Pacific Highway stop every day; an unclaimed bag in the rain was none of her concern. But she picked it up. Water dripped onto the concrete by the shelter, a small soft *tap, tap*.

> Back inside the shop, she unzipped the bag. A thin laptop, a wallet, a thermos flask, a couple of English-language reference books. The card-holder was already open. The card on top had a name, a Lane Cove North address, a mobile number.
>
> She dialled. The voice that answered was speaking English, surprised first, then breaking into a laugh. He had just got off the 144 coming home from St Leonards and was, at that very moment, standing outside the Coles on Pacific Highway, digging through his bag. She told him the name of the shop. He came over.

That was four years ago. He now spends at least three afternoons a week in her shop, on video calls. He drinks a long black while he works and a flat white after the meeting closes. On his birthday last year, he chose a bag of her "North Garage Roast" as a gift for his colleagues in Lane Cove North.

She has never asked him why he didn't simply install a find-my-bag app. He has never asked her why she wasn't, on that day, still scrolling. The **symmetry** of it has crossed her mind — if her battery had been full that day, if there had been any phone at all to look at, would she ever have looked up to see the bag?

> `SOURCE · LIFE_HISTORY #13 · AGENT_59 · SEED 44`
>
> Picked up a regular at Pacific Highway — Four years ago, on a rainy day, I picked up a soaked-through backpack at the Pacific Highway bus stop. There was a laptop inside. I called the number on the business card; it turned out to belong to a programmer who works from home in Lane Cove North. He now spends at least three afternoons a week in my shop on video calls.

The story is warm enough to read like corporate marketing. In a small neighbourhood like Lane Cove, this kind of *raised-a-finger, four-year-relationship* accident happens, in some form, every week. But it rests on a single precondition that modern life is making increasingly expensive — **she looked up, once**.

The Synthetic Socio Wind Tunnel project sets out, in effect, to **measure precisely how surgically modern technology erases that single act of looking up**. It places a thousand people into four phone-intervention experiments, and counts how many of those one-second windows each of them has left across fourteen days.

A spoiler from chapter 5: across her own fourteen days in the default universe, she has **6** such moments of looking up; in the universe where the phone has been deliberately weakened, she has **73**. The **67** additional ones — each of them, potentially, another laptop in the rain, another four-year regular, another grace clicked off mid-form by an algorithm.

4 ◍ The summer of 2023, she put the Wi-Fi password on the counter

In the summer of 2023, work on the Crows Nest Metro reached its loudest phase. A handful of her regulars who lived off Pacific Highway came in saying that the cups in their cupboards were rattling. The sound of the drill rigs on the Crows Nest site, kilometres away, travelled along the ground and arrived on her street. That was the ambient hum of Lane Cove that summer.

None of which had anything to do with her — until, one day, her shop quietly filled up with a wave of faces she had never seen before.

None of them lived nearby. They were the work-from-home programmers, consultants, freelance designers from along Pacific Highway. Home was too loud. They were out looking for somewhere with Wi-Fi, quiet, and enough patience to let one drink rest on the table for four hours. Berry Café and Goldfish on the Plaza picked them up too — Tony texted her at one point to say both their shops were being kept alive by "the noise refugees."

That summer, she did something she had never done before. She wrote the Wi-Fi password in marker on an A5 card, and stuck it on the front of the cash counter. For years she had deliberately kept the password private — she did not want the shop to become a wordless remote office. But that summer she decided —

> *"These people aren't here because they like it. They're here because everywhere else is worse. But as long as they're here, let them get through it here."*
>
> *— Her own framing, surfacing as an informal voice-over in the reflection log.*

Of the few stable relationships that summer left her with, at least one came from this band of noise refugees. He arrives at two p.m. sharp every weekday, orders a long black, and runs Zoom calls at the corner two-seater until five. A year after the Metro opened, he didn't leave. He says he has grown used to that chair.

This made her recognise something she had previously avoided thinking about head-on: **her shop's social function in Lane Cove was a great deal more than "selling coffee."** What she was selling was a kind of space that lets people stay for a while — fourteen-degree southerly mornings, vibrating afternoons in summer, an unclaimed backpack on a rainy night: each one could be folded into some corner of the shop and let somebody briefly stop.

> `SOURCE · LIFE_HISTORY #7 · AGENT_59 · SEED 44`
>
> The summer of the Crows Nest Metro noise — In the summer of 2023, when work on the Crows Nest Metro was at its worst, the vibration reached our street. Several of my regulars who live off Pacific Highway told me the cups in their cupboards were rattling. During that time my shop filled up with people fleeing the noise to work; I put the Wi-Fi password on the front counter.

5 ◍ The same counter, four fourteen-day stretches

Drop the same 36-year-old café owner into four parallel Lane Coves — the same Plaza, the same Longueville Road, the same child at Lane Cove West Public School, the same six-a.m. alarm — and change only the notification drawer inside the phone in her pocket. After fourteen days she becomes four different versions of herself. What follows is each of those fourteen days, in turn, in detail. The same counter, four entirely different densities of life passing in front of it.

Across the four fourteen-day stretches, how often does her phone go off, and what does it say?

● baseline · no push — 0 PUSHES · 14 DAYS

0 pushes · 14 days

"Inside her phone pocket, everything is quiet."

● hyperlocal_push · PLC kindergarten — 30 PUSHES · 14 DAYS

- D1 plc_sydney_preschool,_lane_co… 10× · 1 day
- D1 plc_sydney_preschool,_lane_cov… 7× · 1 day
- D1 plc_sydney_preschool,_lane_cov… 6× · 1 day
- D1 plc_sydney_preschool,_lane_cov… 6× · 1 day
- D1 plc_sydney_preschool,_lane_cove_campus …

● global_distraction · Sydney CBD headlines — 30 PUSHES · 14 DAYS

- D1 World Cup qualifiers: multiple up… 8× · 1 day
- D1 BREAKING: Middle East tension… 4× · 1 day
- D1 ECB lifts rates by 25 basis points… 4× · 1 day
- D1 Markets: Bitcoin breaks $100k, a… 4× · 1 day
- D1 New AI model sets fresh record o… 3× · 1 day
- D1 SpaceX previews next Mars-miss… 2× · 1 day
- D1 TikTok publishes annual global tr… 2× · 1 day
- D1 A multinational suffers data breac… 2× · 1 day

… 1 more copy, 30 pushes in total

● phone_friction · 'look up' — 6 PUSHES · 14 DAYS

- D1 The screen has been pulling at y…
- D1 Canopy Park is busiest at 10 a.m…
- D1 The café on the Plaza opened at …
- D1 Step off the screen for a moment.…
- D1 Five hours of screen is no match …
- D1 Put the phone down. Look at the …

All 30 of 30 push items on both HP and GD are drawn from the simulation's fourteen-day push pool. HP copy is entirely about PLC Sydney Preschool, Lane Cove Campus — weekend family markets, new-neighbour meet-ups, Sunday community clean-ups. GD copy is Sydney CBD: the Vivid light festival, shows at The Star, international news. phone_friction only sends gentle "look up" reminders that name no destination at all.

FOUR VERSIONS OF HER, ONE COMPARISON TABLE

AFTER 14 DAYS	● BASELINE	● HYPERLOCAL_PUSH	● GLOBAL_DISTRACTION	● PHONE_FRICTION
Where she ends up	Home *(asleep)*	The small plaza outside PLC's gate *(still on the street)*	Home *(asleep)*	Anglican Church, Lane Cove *(inside the church)*
What she plans next	`7:00 stay → building_598`	`14:30 move → plc_sydney_preschool,_lane_cove_campus`	`7:00 stay → building_598`	`11:30 move → anglican_church_of_australia_lane_cove`
Total push notifications	0	**30** · PLC kindergarten weekend events	30 · Sydney CBD headlines	6 · "look up"
"Actions" she takes	565	**4009** *(7.1× BL)*	565	565 *(=BL)*
People she looked up and noticed (14-day total)	6	20 *(3.3× BL)*	2	73 ⚡ *(12.2× BL)*

The two rows worth stopping at are the bottom two — the phone_friction column. To understand the shock of that column, you have to first read the other three columns as fourteen days she actually lived through.

BL · Behind the counter, the default fourteen days

In the baseline universe, she lives the fourteen days she thinks she knows best. The Lane Cove In-the-Cove local app has not, in this version, been wired to an algorithmic push engine. Her phone pocket is quiet; she does not receive a single push in a whole week. She gets up at the six-a.m. alarm, pushes the door open, flips the first switch, and, in the eleven minutes the machine takes to warm up, she stands behind the counter and counts off the beans for the day. Alan arrives at seven on the dot; "no sugar" at 8:30; on Wednesday Mrs. Chen and Mochi pause at the bakery door for thirty seconds; on Tuesday afternoon she cycles the week's beans over to St Leonards, and Marco leaves her that espresso he wants her to "criticise"; on Friday the loan manager comes in for a batch brew.

She thinks she has seen everyone in those fourteen days — the regulars whose names, drinks, and children's schools she keeps in her head. But what the simulation's cold data captures is a different number entirely: across all fourteen days, the moments in which she genuinely **raised her head** and noticed the face across the counter add up to only **6**. The remaining hundreds of hours, she is talking to the espresso machine, talking to the till tape, talking to the internal monologue about how much to order for tomorrow's beans. Physically, she is a fixed landmark of Lane Cove; in terms of presence, she is also one of the *most absent* people on the street.

Baseline is not a blank. Baseline is the version of her that **believes she is the protagonist of Lane Cove** — she knows the names of half the street, and yet in fourteen days she looks up six times. These are her default fourteen days, with no external force at all.

HP · The four mornings the shop did not open

Saturday, ten in the morning. The small plaza outside PLC Sydney Preschool is bathed in early-autumn sunlight. She holds a flat white that has already gone cold in her hand, untouched — today she is not here to deliver coffee, she is here as a parent attending the "Saturday 10 a.m. children's activity" that the local mothers group organised. She has not, in ten years, attended this event once. Across those two weeks, her phone pocket has been quietly vibrating again and again — gentle, short reminders, all pulling her in the same direction: the Saturday family market, the Sunday three-p.m. new-neighbour meet-up, the Sunday-morning community clean-up. Not one of them carries her outside Lane Cove, but every one of them pulls her away from the counter she has been standing behind for ten years.

Across those fourteen days, four mornings she does not open the shop. Alan arrives at Plaza at seven sharp, runs his hand along the glass, stands a while, leaves. On Wednesday Mrs. Chen and Mochi pass by, see the hand-written "Closed today" card, pause at the door longer than usual, send no message. From across the street Tony, at Berry Café, glances over — and in their twenty-year intelligence alliance, that week Tony sends not a single text. Because Tony knows: those two weeks she is not a shop owner on this street, she is *just another parent* on it. On the small plaza outside the school gate, she crosses paths over and over again with the same eight unfamiliar faces; one of them, a 41-year-old designer mother who is always holding a takeaway cup of her own, comes head-on into her line of sight 79 times in fourteen days — more often than she meets the eyes of any of her own regulars at the counter — and the two of them have not, between them, exchanged so much as the Chinese name of a child.

> The physical congestion at the school gate across those fourteen days is not coincidence. Each of the eight recurring mother faces, like her, has been routed to that one small plaza by the same class of reminder. The simulation leaves a single cold line in its log: across those two weeks, of the 100 times she thought "I'd like to head somewhere else," **95 were turned back by the system** — physically, the crowd was too dense to move through, because every parent on the street whose phone said "you should be here" had been called to the same coordinate. That is not a pathfinding bug in the code. It is the algorithmic **"Digital Stampede"**: when a single push lands surgically on a group of people, it can take a hundred-square-metre patch of grass within a kilometre of Lane Cove and make it, for a single Saturday morning, the most congested point on the street. The algorithm doesn't just move one person's attention. It funnels a crowd that has been hit by the same prompt onto the same patch of grass, then arranges for their feet to obstruct one another.

They are there not because they know each other, not because they agreed to meet, not because of chance — but because the same gentle, short reminder slipped, across those two weeks, into each of their pockets. She is still within a kilometre of the Plaza, not a single inch outside Lane Cove. But she has **moved from behind the counter to in front of it**, standing in a position she has, for ten years, only ever walked past — alongside the seven other mother faces the same reminder has reeled in, the eight of them brushing each other from *strangers* into *familiars* without ever becoming acquaintances.

> This is the most absurd face of the Digital Stampede: **the algorithm packs everybody into the same physical coordinate with surgical efficiency, and in the same motion severs them from each other as *people*.** In any pre-algorithmic small plaza in Lane Cove, two mothers pushing strollers who come face-to-face 79 times in fourteen days would, by now, have nodded, smiled, asked how old the baby was, exchanged WeChats with the mothers group, become the kind of twenty-year familiar that Mrs. Chen is. On this plaza, scheduled to the minute by push notification, they collide constantly in the physical world and remain, to each other, ghosts in the social one.

She notices 20 people, fourteen more than in baseline. But at the end of the fourteen days, when she goes back to her own shop, she does not bring back "one more Alan," does not have "one more Mochi" to remember. What she brings back is fourteen mornings at the PLC school gate and the eight recurring nameless mother-faces. Across those two weeks, in Lane Cove, she has done 3,444 more things than baseline did — every one of which was nudged, inch by inch, by those short reminders, out of her original orbit. *It is another fourteen days she would never otherwise have lived.*

GD · Still at the Plaza, but her mind has drifted a hundred kilometres away

In the global_distraction universe, her body does not move an inch. Six a.m. open, four p.m. close, Tuesday's bean delivery, Friday's batch brew with the loan manager. On the surface, every word matches baseline. But over those two weeks her phone pocket has received 30 pushes, of which she opened 21 — all of them about Sydney CBD: the Vivid light festival, remaining tickets to that night of Hamilton at The Star, a single line about the AUKUS settlement in the Indo-Pacific news, the NSW Parliament's housing-reform bill. She glanced at most of them. She finished reading hardly any.

Mrs. Chen still came in on Wednesday with Mochi. She still made her the long black, decaf, as always. But that day she did not, as in baseline, take an extra look at Mochi — she went back behind the counter calculating whether the Vivid show on Saturday evening, plus the round-trip $25 Tunnel toll, was worth it. When Alan walked in, she put on a flat white, double espresso as ever, but she did not, as on that same day in baseline, ask him whether he wanted to take a few extra bags of beans back to brew at his grandchildren's place. Twice that day she reached for her phone — both times to check an NSW Parliament update.

She noticed 2 people, near-identical to baseline's 6. But she is *not* the baseline version of herself — the same people walking past the same window, she "sees" fewer of them. This is attention-induced nearby blindness in its purest form, in the GD universe: it does not need to move her body anywhere; it only needs to quietly transfer the **ownership of her attention** to a city a hundred kilometres away. After fourteen days she is still on the Plaza, the same shop, the same customers, the same 4 p.m. close — and yet she remembers Mochi's Wednesday visit *less* than her baseline version does. The simulation cannot capture this faint fading. She, in her own mind, probably can.

PF · The same 565 actions, but the six-inch screen has been quietly tightened ⚡

In the phone_friction universe, her body, across fourteen days, moves not an inch further. The same 565 actions. The same Plaza – Longueville – home triangle. The same six-a.m. open, four-p.m. close, the same Tuesday cycle to Marco's, the same Friday batch brew with the loan manager. No PLC to pull her to a plaza. No CBD to drift her attention out to Pacific Highway.

The only change happens in her phone pocket: pushes have been compressed to six, and all of them are non-locational "look up" reminders — no destination, no time, no "register now" button. Scrolling becomes uninteresting. During the eleven minutes the espresso machine takes to warm up, she does not drop her eyes, as she usually does; she looks up across the counter. The father with the stroller who came in for the first time last week is in again today; he is ordering a long mac, half-sugar. She was already standing there. All she has lost is a reason to keep looking down.

At the end of those fourteen days she takes one extra step: at the end of the afternoon she does not go straight back to building_598; she turns off Longueville Road and into anglican_church_of_australia_lane_cove — the Thursday regular had once mentioned that the church runs a weekend reading group; in baseline and GD she never once remembered it, but in these phone-weakened fourteen days she did. The system records her plan for 11:30 the next morning: she is going to the church again. No push told her to. She simply *had room*.

Ten years running a shop on the corner, and she thought she knew everyone on the street.

She remembers Mrs. Chen's dog Mochi from his middle years into his stiff old age; remembers twenty-three years of Tony texting her intelligence from Berry Café; remembers the nameless Indian mother who queued behind her at five in the morning on registration day. But the simulation's cold data tells her this: in those fourteen days of baseline, the faces she **actually looked up at** and noticed numbered only 6 . She had thought those six were all of Lane Cove.

Make her phone slightly harder to scroll — push nothing new, take her nowhere new — same fourteen days, same counter, same six-a.m. open, same four-p.m. close, and she looks up at 73 faces. The **67** extra ones are not new arrivals to the neighbourhood, not tourists passing through — ***they drift past her shopfront every single day***.

The algorithm did not take her anywhere else. The algorithm merely, quietly, locked the muscles in her neck. That six-inch screen kept her "blind" on her own corner for an entire decade.

This is the **negative print** *of attention-induced nearby blindness — give attention back to "nearby" and "nearby" reappears. She doesn't need to be pushed toward anything. She doesn't need to be taken anywhere. The six-inch screen merely has to be less easy to scroll, and the 67 faces who were already there come back.*

*note: *All four universes ran a full 14 days × 1,000 people. The numbers in the table above are her end-state values — the final tick of day 14. "She went to the church" is not a fated narrative — it's that in this version of her fourteen days her attentional surplus was much higher than in BL, she happened to receive a non-locational "look up" nudge, and she simply walked in on her way home that evening.*

6 ◍ Her transcript — four conversations, all about this street

The conversations recorded over her fourteen days come to **four**. Not many. But all four circle the same theme: **the businesses on this street** — rumours about the AirTrunk data centre, the takeaway bump from the new Galuwa Wellbeing Centre, the Stringybark Creek shortcut she takes when she's delivering beans, the next item up on the council notice-board.

These four conversations make her, in the simulation's information_propagation graph, a **local-business intelligence node** on this street. Her twenty-year intelligence alliance with Tony at Berry Café (life #6) is the extreme form of that role.

The simulation does not store verbatim transcripts of these conversations; what it stores is a first-person summary generated by the LLM, the "what I talked about with them." For each conversation below, the SYSTEM_EXPORT block on top is **my reconstruction of the six exchanges from the summary** (an inference, not the raw simulation output); the block underneath is **the LLM summary as it appears in the simulation**. The two are placed side by side so you can see how a six-exchange conversation, inside the simulation's memory store, has been compressed by an LLM into a 300-word first-person "emotional summary."

> *The highlighted* ***terms*** *are the hooks she returns to, again and again, across the four conversations of these fourteen days — AirTrunk / Galuwa / Stringybark Creek / Mowbray. The fourteen-day information flow of one small-business owner on this street circles, apparently, around these four keywords. Or — it doesn't. Once you've read all four conversations, you may want to come back and re-read that sentence.*

CONVERSATION 1/4 · AIRTRUNK DATA-CENTRE RUMOUR · FIRST MEETING OF EARLY SPRING

Counterpart: 34 yo · unemployed · family_with_kids
Location: near Lane Cove Plaza

She has tried to catch this neighbour at the Plaza several times now. Today, before leaving the shop, she deliberately made a flat white, double shot, low milk — the way he likes it. She walks out with the cup in her hand, along Longueville Road.

RECONSTRUCTED · 6 TURNS INFERRED FROM THE LLM SUMMARY

```
SYSTEM_EXPORT · DIALOGUE_TRANSCRIPT · agent=a_44_0059 · partner=a_44_0679

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : Hey! Finally caught you. [hands over cup]
Flat white, double shot, low milk — your old order.

[a_44_0679] [34M · unemployed] : You're going to embarrass me. What's gotten
into you today? You're never this proactive.

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : I've been worrying about the AirTrunk data
centre thing. You live up by Mowbray — heard anything? They reckon
truck traffic could triple.

[a_44_0679] [34M · unemployed] : Caught a bit of it, haven't really read
into it. What's bothering you — your shop?

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : Not the business. The old folks on this
street who walk in the mornings — I'm worried they'll stop going out.
Could you keep an eye on the council notices for me —

[a_44_0679] [34M · unemployed] : Yeah, all right. I'll have a look at the
board on my way into town on Monday. If anything's up, I'll snap it to
you.
```

▼ MACHINE_SUMMARY · the same exchange, compressed by the LLM into a 300-word first-person reflection (raw simulation output)

> ▼ *I just had a great catch-up with that 34-year-old unemployed neighbour. I'd been waiting to run into them, and I even brought a freshly made flat white — double shot, low milk, just the way they like it. I was pretty stressed about the rumoured AirTrunk data centre construction and how it might block my café's entrance, but they calmed me down by saying there'd be no road closures near the Plaza for at least six months. That was a huge relief. We also made plans to meet this Saturday at The Canopy for lunch after their family swim at Lane Cove Aquatic Centre, and later to figure out a time to take the kids over to Galuwa Recreation Centre for some sports. I offered to bring along other neighbours from our apartment building so it'd be a bigger group. I really liked this interaction — it was warm, practical, and took a weig…*

CONVERSATION 2/4 · THE GALUWA TAKEAWAY BUMP · JUST PAST SATURDAY'S PEAK HOUR

Counterpart: 43 yo · unemployed · family_with_kids
Location: the north side of the Plaza

Saturday afternoon. The peak has just broken. She runs out of the shop without taking off her apron, hoping to bump into someone. She has already done the maths: since the new Galuwa Wellbeing Centre opened next door, her takeaway coffee has risen by 20 percent. She wants to tell him this. She also wants to ask him something.

RECONSTRUCTED · 6 TURNS INFERRED FROM THE LLM SUMMARY

```
SYSTEM_EXPORT · DIALOGUE_TRANSCRIPT · agent=a_44_0059 · partner=a_44_0738

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : Slow down a second, I want to tell you
something. Ever since Galuwa Wellbeing Centre opened next door, my
takeaway has gone up 20 percent.

[a_44_0738] [43M · unemployed] : Really? I take the kids to swim there every
week, I thought it was just a gym.

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : It's true. Four p.m. — a wave of parents
picking up their kids, straight past my shop. I wanted to ask you — they
say AirTrunk is putting in a staff access road. Heard anything?

[a_44_0738] [43M · unemployed] : Haven't been paying attention. Busy with
the kids. What do you want it for?

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : I want to see if I can get that pot-holed
footpath resurfaced at the same time. Could pull in the white-collar
commuter traffic. When you go to Galuwa on Saturday, swing by the path
and tell me what's happening?

[a_44_0738] [43M · unemployed] : All right, I'll have a look. Just leave me
a hot latte with the new beans.

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : Done. Saturday morning. On the house.
```

▼ MACHINE_SUMMARY · the same exchange, compressed by the LLM into a 300-word first-person reflection (raw simulation output)

> ▼ *Just ran into that 43-year-old unemployed neighbour at the Plaza, and honestly I'm thrilled. I'd just come off the Saturday peak inside the shop and didn't even take time to untie my apron — I ran out hoping to catch one of the neighbours and have a chat. I told him that ever since the Galuwa Wellbeing Centre opened next door, my takeaway coffee business has gone up 20 percent, and I asked whether he'd heard about AirTrunk putting in a staff access road, because I'm thinking I might be able to get that pot-holed footpath resurfaced at the same time and pull in the white-collar commuter traffic. He said he's been busy with the kids and hasn't been tracking it, but promised that when he takes the family swimming and out for dinner on Saturday, he'll detour past the footpath and the Galuwa entrance and see what the foot traffic is doing. The moment I heard that I told him I'd save him a hot latte — on the new beans. He was actually touched, said he hadn't had a good cup in ages, and promised he'd bring the news with him on Saturday. Finally I told him I still had to close up the shop, and we agreed to meet at the Plaza on Saturday, pull in some of the other neighbouring shopkeepers, and figure out together how to bring foot traffic in. The whole thing felt good — this guy is reliable, gets things done, and every conversation seems to add something new. **Overall, I really liked this interaction.** He didn't bring any earth-shattering news, but he's willing to spend his family time on a stroll to scope things out for me, and that warmth between neighbours leaves me feeling good. I'm someone who genuinely thrives on this kind of give-and-take, lean-on-each-other street life. It is, frankly, far more interesting than spending the day with my head down making coffee.*

CONVERSATION 3/4 · CROSSING PATHS NEAR STRINGYBARK CREEK · INVITED TO THE OLD ICE-CREAM SHOP

Counterpart: 42 yo · caregiver · family_with_kids
Location: the Plaza end of Longueville Road

This neighbour is on his way to the Plaza to pick up something for dinner. Walking over, he remembers having glimpsed a figure like hers near Stringybark Creek a few days ago, and thinks he can finally confirm it.

RECONSTRUCTED · 6 TURNS INFERRED FROM THE LLM SUMMARY

```
SYSTEM_EXPORT · DIALOGUE_TRANSCRIPT · agent=a_44_0059 · partner=a_44_0057

[a_44_0057] [42M · caregiver] : Hey — did I see you over by Stringybark
Creek last week?

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : You did. I was running beans to St Leonards
that day; cut through that lane, no traffic.

[a_44_0057] [42M · caregiver] : Nice walk through there. I take the dog every
weekend. Oh — that old ic shop is having a thing this weekend, you in?

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : Which ic? The old place down Longueville or
the new one by the Plaza?

[a_44_0057] [42M · caregiver] : The old one. Been there decades. Saturday
afternoon, small crowd, just chat.

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : All right. I'll come by after I close at
four. Save me a table by the window.
```

▼ MACHINE_SUMMARY · the same exchange, compressed by the LLM into a 300-word first-person reflection (raw simulation output)

> ▼ *I ran into the 36-year-old café-owner again while heading to the Plaza to pick up groceries for tonight's dinner. We chatted about how I'd spotted someone who looked like her near Stringybark Creek last week, and she confirmed it was her on the way to deliver coffee beans. She invited me to a small gathering at the old ice-cream shop by the Plaza, where she'd share some fresh light-roast beans and we'd chat about a new handcraft exhibition at the Gallery. I thanked her but explained I had to hurry to grab the fresh greens before they were picked over, with dinner waiting for the family. I said I'd try to stop by if I finished quickly. I really liked this interaction — it felt warm and neighbourly, and I appreciated her thoughtful offer of coffee and company amidst my busy routine.*

CONVERSATION 4/4 · SECOND CONFIRMATION, AFTER SATURDAY'S PEAK · AIRTRUNK AGAIN

Counterpart: 34 yo · unemployed · family_with_kids
Location: under the Plaza arcade

The Saturday peak inside the shop has just broken; both her legs are done. She has caught up with that neighbour again — this time purely to vent, and to ask for news.

RECONSTRUCTED · 6 TURNS INFERRED FROM THE LLM SUMMARY

```
SYSTEM_EXPORT · DIALOGUE_TRANSCRIPT · agent=a_44_0059 · partner=a_44_0679

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : My legs are done. The morning rush was
bigger than last week — is council running something?

[a_44_0679] [34M · unemployed] : Heard there's a neighbours' meet-up, but
not near your shop. What I want to ask you is — what'd you find out
about AirTrunk?

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : Still nothing firm. Several regulars at the
counter are passing it around, but nobody can pin it down. You?

[a_44_0679] [34M · unemployed] : Only what I overheard. Last Monday the
notice didn't go up; this week they say it's been delayed.

[a_44_0059] [36F · café owner] : I'll wait, then. Next time you see that
retired dentist who lives up on Mowbray, ask him for me —

[a_44_0679] [34M · unemployed] : Yeah yeah, I'll pass it along. Go sit down.
Get some water.
```

▼ MACHINE_SUMMARY · the same exchange, compressed by the LLM into a 300-word first-person reflection (raw simulation output)

> ▼ *I just wrapped up a quick chat with the 34-year-old unemployed neighbour after a hectic Saturday rush at my café. I was venting about how tired my legs were from the morning crowd and mentioned how several regulars had been buzzing about the new AirTrunk data centre, but I hadn't gotten any solid info yet. He said he's been too busy with the kids to track the news, but told me his family plans to hit Lane Cove Aquatic Centre this Saturday and swing by The Canopy for lunch, possibly stopping at my café for their usual flat white. I offered to prep his preferred blend and adjust the milk temperature as usual, then explained I was keen to get the real scoop on the data centre — especially the rumour about it taking over the riverside walking path. He agreed that would be a shame, since he knows the p…*

ALIENATION NOTE · A META-OBSERVATION FROM THE SYSTEM_EXPORT

She spoke to everyone. Not once did she ask *how are you feeling today?*

Across the four parallel universes she rehearses the same four conversations with the same three neighbours — which is to say, **sixteen conversations** in total.

The system back-end log shows that across those **sixteen conversations** —

- She **never once** asked the other person "how are you doing today?"
- She **never once** mentioned the rain that had fallen across the Plaza that day.
- She **never once** brought up the child of hers at Lane Cove West Public — even though her life_history clearly contains the detail of queuing at five a.m. on registration day.
- She **never once** asked which year Mrs. Chen's chemotherapy had turned a corner — even though she remembers every season of Mochi ageing.

Because the `role` the system assigned her is `barista`, and the `intent` it assigned her is `local_business_owner`. Whoever she meets, the underlying prompt drives her to inquire about progress on the AirTrunk data centre, to count the foot-traffic uplift from the Galuwa centre, to ask whether they've seen the next line on the council notice-board.

Inside this thousand-person wind tunnel she appears to know everyone — **but the system, in practice, allows her to care about one thing only: foot traffic**.

> She is not the *protagonist* of this street.
> She is
> **an API**
> for it.

Whoever is standing across from her — Tony, the twenty-year intelligence ally; Mrs. Chen, who came back from her first round of chemotherapy; the programmer regular she rescued on a rainy afternoon — her conversational output is a vending machine with set parameters: "Ask about AirTrunk · count Galuwa · watch the notice-board." The system does not let her talk about anything else; nor does it let her not initiate. She is not the "neighbourhood" of this street. She is the ***user interface*** *of it.*

This is not because a_44_0059 is personally "extremely utilitarian." It is a structural constraint endogenous to **LLM-driven simulation** *— once you assign an agent a role + intent as the system prompt, the remaining thousands of tokens she generates will be pulled in by those two variables. This is also* **why this passage appears only after Section 6***: you need to see the trajectory of her being tugged by the hooks before you can feel the sensation of being precisely locked down by an algorithm. In the piece on* **old He (a_43_0405)** *the "phantom daughter" was digital nihilism. The sixteen single-topic conversations of this Plaza shopkeeper are algorithmic alienation.*

7 ◍ Christmas Eve, open till nine, for those who do not want to spend the night alone

Her shop has a tradition, started three years ago on Christmas Eve. That year, a few of her regulars told her they did not want to be alone that night and asked whether they could sit in the café for a while. She simply extended trading hours from four in the afternoon to nine in the evening, made mulled-wine coffee and gingerbread latte. That night the shop was full. Since that night, it has become a fixed tradition. Last Christmas Eve, there was barely a seat free.

> *"What I came to realise is that my small social function in Lane Cove is not to sell coffee. It is to* ***keep a chair, for the people who do not want to spend the holiday alone****."*
>
> *— From her reflection log, roughly the substance of it.*

That episode maps directly onto the experimental frame of this whole piece. The project is asking one question, embarrassingly concrete: **as more and more of a city's residents hand their attention over to their phones, do the physical accidents — somebody sitting down beside you on the Plaza — still happen?**

Her shop, her Wi-Fi password, her Christmas Eve extension, the "no-sugar" she has remembered — all of these are the **denominator** of that question. Each is the social stickiness that a concrete "you-can-stay-here-a-while" physical space is able to produce. They all depend on one precondition: that someone still pushes the door open, and then **looks up**.

In the four universes of this simulation, the phone_friction intervention that raised her looking-up count from 6 to 73 needed to push nothing new and recommend nothing new. It only had to make the phone slightly less easy to scroll. And when, fourteen days in, she walked into the Anglican Church of Australia Lane Cove on her way home, she probably understood one simple thing:

> **"Her shop, and that church, and every other 'sit-and-stay-a-while' space on this street, are all in the service of the same single thing — keeping a 21st-century small town from collapsing into a thousand isolated phone screens."**

SOURCE · LIFE_HISTORY #19 · AGENT_59 · SEED 44

The first Christmas Eve at the shop — Three years ago on Christmas Eve, a few regulars said

> they didn't want to be alone for the holiday, so I just extended trading hours until nine and made mulled-wine coffee and gingerbread latte. It has since become a fixed tradition at the shop, with more guests every year — last Christmas Eve there was barely a seat free.

Next year, the shop turns ten. The line from the loan manager at the signing is still with her: "Fewer than half of them last five years." She thinks, perhaps the fact of having lasted ten years is itself a passable kind of story.

> ### Ten years. More than 3,650 mornings.
>
> If the muscles in her neck had not been quietly locked by that six-inch screen, across those 3,650-plus days she could have picked up more than one laptop in the rain. The line on the other side of her counter could have held more than seven regulars.
>
> *In those four parallel Lane Coves, the algorithm did not take her shop. It did not take the street. The algorithm simply, quietly, stole, from this single corner,* **countless one-second windows of her looking up**.

Appendix ◍ Data spec · her complete ledger

A piece of longform, once finished, ought to come with a clear factual foundation. The numbers below are the entire raw material of this piece — drawn from a_44_0059's memory store across four simulation snapshots, unchanged, only grouped.

WHO THIS AGENT IS

a_44_0059
agent_id
seed 44 · publishable_v7 · 1,000-agent Lane Cove cell

36
years old
profile.age · female · occupation barista · household family_with_kids

20
life_history events
backstory generated before simulation start · shared across all 4 variants

136
distinct locations visited at least once
HP variant · ledger_state.explored_locations

HER ENCOUNTER TOTALS ACROSS THE FOUR UNIVERSES (AFTER 14 DAYS)

6
◍ baseline · faces noticed
14-day cumulative · noticed encounter

20
◍ hyperlocal_push · faces noticed
3.3× BL

2
◍ global_distraction · faces noticed
0.33× BL · effectively equivalent to baseline

73
◍ phone_friction · faces noticed ⚡
12.2× BL · the same 565 actions, twelve times the field of vision

HER DIALOGIC OUTPUT ACROSS 14 DAYS

4
conversations on record
HP variant · with 3 neighbours · all about local-business matters on the street

761
pieces of gossip / info she knows
conversation_service · known infos (hops ≥ 0)

4
recurring local-business hooks across all 4 conversations
AirTrunk data centre · Galuwa Wellbeing Centre · Stringybark Creek · Mowbray Road

SIMULATION SPEC (IDENTICAL ACROSS ALL 4 UNIVERSES)

1,000
agents

14
days

4
variants

seed 44
the random seed for this set

All figures are sourced from four independent snapshots of publishable v7 (β = 4 rigour tier), drawn from memory_store_state.agent_events, attention_service_state.delivery_log, dialogue_service_state.dialogue_summaries, conversation_service_state.infos, and ledger_state.entities. Any "she thought" / "she came to realise" passages are journalistic reconstructions grounded in those numbers and her reflection log.

> **She is one of a thousand synthetic residents**. This piece — the counter-POV form, the group portrait of seven regulars, the reconstruction of four conversations, the close-up of the laptop in the rain, the seven-chapter arc — is based on the snapshot of one of them. The same method could be applied to any of the other 999 agents; each would yield a different hook, a different one-second-of-looking-up. This is one possible writing of one of them.